

Ohio River Trail Council



1100 Pennsylvania Av
Monaca, Pa 15061
724-728-2625

MINUTES

DATE 9-30-2013

TIME 6:00 PM

HOLIDAY INN EXPRESS, MONACA, PA

MEETING CALLED BY	Dr. Vincent Troia
TYPE OF MEETING	Board Meeting
FACILITATOR	Dr. Vincent Troia
NOTE TAKER	Donna Campbell, Secretary

Members Present: Dr. Vincent Troia, Paul Rogers, Bill Sweterlisch, Mitch Pfeiffer, Marlin Erin, Greg Kalamasz, Chris Rishack, Julie Peck, Donna Campbell

DISCUSSION	Dr. Vincent Troia opened the meeting with an introduction of all members present. A motion to approve the minutes of the last meeting was made by Bill Sweterlisch; Marlin Erin seconded the motion. All were in favor.
DISCUSSION	Dr. Vincent Troia reported that the Chubb insurance premiums for the General liability policy would cost a total of \$700.00. In order for us to receive support from National Park Service we must carry an additional umbrella policy at a cost of \$1,173.00. The National Park Service has granted us \$1200.00 to cover the cost of the premium. The Directors and Officers premium is \$700.00 and an additional \$700.00 was spent for Event Insurance for the Fall Music Festival, which did not included coverage for serving liquor. Vendors were required to cover this cost and supplied certificates of additional insured.
DISCUSSION	Dr. Vincent Troia recently spoke to Todd Stevenson regarding the proposed merger between the ORTC and the Beaver River Rails-to-Trails Association. At the September board meeting the BRRTA discussed the matter and their opinion is that an alliance or partnership is acceptable but not a merger. They expressed concerns about the twenty five year history involving the founding fathers and the question of their legal standing if their 501(C) 3 status is lost. They do not want to dissolve their 501 status. There is approximately one mile of trail completed by the BRRTA in Beaver Falls. There are some challenges with extending the trail beyond the present ending point because Geneva College sold the railroad station that is adjacent to the trail after trail construction was started and the new owner is not supportive of the greenway. Dr. Vincent Troia reminded the group "not to give up hope" on the merger because he believes that "at some point it will happen". Dr. Troia stressed that a partnership would reduce the struggle of competition for competing revenues and memberships, infuse creativity, improve efficiency and save on operating costs."

DISCUSSION	Dr. Troia reviewed the schedule for the planned ORTC River sweep for 2014. Dr. Troia stated that instead of waiting until summer when the weeds mature and the temperatures rise that it may be a better idea to have the cleanup in the spring. It was noted that Independence Conservancy normally schedules theirs in the spring. Dr. Troia reported that we can partner with Bridgestone Tire because they will collect and recycle all tires as part of the River Network Tire Program. The National River Clean-up will supply trash bags and on-line promotion. No dates have been finalized at this time but we are looking at some time in April coordinating this with Vickie and the Independence Conservancy.
DISCUSSION	Dr. Vincent Troia presented "Day of Giving 2013" which is an initiative of the Pittsburgh Foundation, which will match any donation to the ORTC up to \$1,000.00. The match percentage will be calculated after the drive is complete. Day of Giving 2013 is scheduled for October 3, 2013 and anyone can donate by logging into www.pittsburghgives.org .
DISCUSSION	The TCSP \$200,000 grant received in January 2012 will be used for Phases 1 in Coraopolis, PA. Marlin Erin commented that someone should ask the County Commissioners where Act 13 Money is being spent. Dr. Vincent Troia said he would set up a meeting to talk to them in regards to funding the trail in Beaver County.
DISCUSSION	Bill Sweterlitsch and Jack Manning made the presentation at the hearing for the ARAD grant. Bill stated that "the process was like going before the Supreme Court, you give your explanation and you are out of there and the next group comes in." He also explained that the \$175,000 ARAD grant is strictly for Allegheny County and must be spent in Coraopolis and Moon Twp. If necessary all money will be spent in Coraopolis as they don't like a project left undone. Bill commented that ARAD or the Allegheny Regional Asset District is funded by the 1% sales tax in Allegheny County with much of their funding going to Port Authority and the Sports Stadiums.
DISCUSSION	Dr. Vincent Troia presented that grants pending are Greenways Trails and Recreation Program - \$250,000; DCNR - \$250,000; Sustainable Pittsburgh, Pedals and Pedestrians - \$15,000. The grants that have been completed are DCNR, \$25,500 for the South Shore Trail Feasibility Study; DCNR, \$30,000 for the North Shore Trail Feasibility Study; EPA Brownfields, \$175,000; Port of Pittsburgh Commission, two grants \$20,000 each and the National Park Service \$11,100 for the water trail development and map & guide publication; Beaver County Foundation Grant, \$1,000.00 for the Monaca Youth Mentoring Program. Marlin Erin asked if anyone was standing in the way on the South Heights side of the trail area. Dr. Vincent Troia reported that Mario Leone had told him that South Heights had met with the EPA and the Commissioners to construct the south shore along the Aliquippa brownfield.
DISCUSSION	Potential changes to the water trail map may be to indicate the Rescue boats locations. In addition, adding the Crescent Township access even though the launch is not paved. A case of the map & guide has been provided to the National Park Service.
DISCUSSION	John Orndorff reported on the North Shore Extension Phase from Glenn Osborne, crossing Sewickley Bridge over to Ambridge could be completed for a reasonable cost. He will attend Ambridge and Sewickley council meetings and make a proposal to ask for funding. This portion of the trail would be share-the-road or bike lane. Beaver Road could be used as it is slow speed and low traffic and is open from Emsworth to Ambridge.
DISCUSSION	Dr. Troia has received numerous phone calls asking about the quickest way to get people from Ohio to the GAP trail. Marlin reported that there is a book detailing the route but most people are using Route 14 to PA51. Marlin stated he has put together route for Adventure Cycling and that there are better Routes than routes with lower traffic than Route 51. The advantage to Route 51 is that it is flat and a simple route. We can investigate other route options once we get financing. Marlin and Dr. Troia will review this. The 4-foot passing law passed April 2, 2012 as well as Share-the-Road and Bike Route signage was reviewed by Dr. Troia.
DISCUSSION	Dr. Vincent Troia reported that Coraopolis and Moon Township have not signed their Intergovernmental Agreements. The purpose of the Intergovernmental Agreement is to establish maintenance guidelines and a working relationship between the municipalities and the ORTC.

DISCUSSION	Dr. Troia reported that bicycle racks have been purchased. Five racks will be given to New Brighton at the fishing pier. Freedom has requested some for their bus stop as well as Bridgewater even though they have already received a 10-bike capacity rack.
DISCUSSION	The Ohio River Water Trail logo was reviewed. The logo was based on a historical perspective. Steamships were built in this area so that was incorporated into the logo as well as the Famous P&LE Railroad Bridge across the Ohio River with the insignia "La Belle Riviere" or the French European name for "beautiful river."
DISCUSSION	Dr. Troia gave everyone a list of launch points for various Kayak outings and showed signage for the ORT safe paddling tips. He reminded us that he would like to add a kayak race to next year's Fall Music Festival. It was also noted that the ORTC owns one kayak.
DISCUSSION	The Steeler Ticket Fundraiser is in progress. A \$10.00 donation is requested for each ticket. Last year the sale was very successful with a \$3540.00 profit. The winner will receive four tickets, parking and \$100.00 spending money. Since the Steelers are not doing as well this season it could affect the outcome of the sale. A golf outing fundraiser was also mentioned
DISCUSSION	The Open House will be held again in 2014 at CCBC in building #9. We will try to have it in May around the 1st of the month.
DISCUSSION	Dr. Troia asked everyone to give some thought to events that could be used to promote the grand opening of the Ohio River Water Trail. One idea would be to have the largest raft of canoes and kayaks for the Guinness Book of World Records. We think we would need 2000 boats on the Beaver River which would put Beaver County on the map. In 2010, Paddle at the Point had 1800 paddlers near Pittsburgh, forming the largest known flotilla and in 2011 Susan G Komen of New York successfully completed "one square mile of hope" with connected paddlers as a fundraiser for cancer research. Perhaps we could incorporate the opening with the Beaver County Regatta. However there are concerns with Bridgewater since customarily non-profits don't have to pay any fees and Bridgewater charges everyone regardless of whether you are a non-profit and they coordinate the River Regatta.
DISCUSSION	The ORTC Specialty License plate will be available to members at the \$50.00 level. We must have application for 300 plates to start the specialty plate program. We could potentially see a profit of \$8650.00 with this program
DISCUSSION	Dr. Troia stressed the economic benefit that trails bring to the communities they pass through. The GAP trail generates \$40+ million in revenue each year and is expected to reach \$60+ million when it is completed to Point State Park. Dr. Troia showed a picture of the Smithfield Street Bridge switchback that will complete the trail from Washington DC to the Point in Pittsburgh at a cost of 3 million.
DISCUSSION	Plans for the 2014 Music Festival were discussed. Marlin Erin thinks if we put on a 5-K running race or a Tour of Beaver County Ride and did not have the expense of a Festival, we may do better than having a full-blown festival. He stated that "Gear and Cheer" does not say anything to a 5-K racer or a bicyclist as opposed to putting it out there as a race or a bike ride. Howl at the Moon was established so the Beaver Track Team could go to State competition for example. It should also be remembered that runners like to run early in the morning. Dr. Troia stated that he does advertise each event separately, especially on Facebook. Julie Peck stated that she ran eight 5-K's this season and knew nothing about our race. She would like to help promote our race to her race people and also stated we have the perfect venue for a relay such as a run, a rock climb, swim and bike ride and could add corporate teams, others could do this solo if they wanted. Marlin does not think it could be done in conjunction with the Festival but could be a separate

	fundraiser. We have to keep in mind that Brady's Run Lake closes at times due to bacteria in the water due to the geese.
DISCUSSION	Bill Sweterlitsch said he would take care of soliciting Wineries and Beer vendors to get them to come for the 2014 Festival. He included that wineries must apply to the State for a temporary license so they can be present at the Festival. Some festivalgoers commented that our Festival beer-tasting fee was too high. Dr. Troia stated that Barks and Brews fee was \$45.00, ours was only \$35.00. Chris Rishack suggested passing out a business-type cards to "save the date." Chris Rishack suggested a kayak race on the lake where you could race out and then pass a float on the outer perimeter and race back. We wouldn't need to purchase kayaks however the National Park Service gave us money to buy them for the Youth Kayaking Program. Marlin stated that it is very hard to get someone to take on these projects. Dr. Troia indicated that the YMCA does not want to do it nor does the Beaver County Rowing Association. Ray Tabay coordinated the kayak race for the Beaver County Regatta. Chris Rishack stressed that we need to get more "Gear Vendors" Paul King commented that perhaps if we had more runners and bicyclist's participation and if the vendors knew this, they would come. Chris suggested ideas for a Duck Race, a low investment project with a high return. Regardless of participant's age, they could purchase a duck when they come to the Festival. The ducks could be dumped of the bridge and whoever gets to the end first wins. Corporations could sponsor a duck and we could have a "travelling trophy" for companies with the "winning duck". Other Family Friendly Festival ideas were a Bounce House and Ball Crawl.
DISCUSSION	Chris stated he also likes to set up adventures, camping, hiking, etc. if that could be incorporated into our efforts. Dr. Troia indicated that he would expand the ORTC Clubs by establishing an ORTC Outdoor Adventure Club through Meetup.
DISCUSSION	Dr. Troia reminded the group that we are at somewhat of a disadvantage as the railroads in Beaver County are alive and thriving. The Montour Trail receives income from the property that they own due to Montour railroad abandonment. Therefore, we must rely on our efforts through grants and fundraisers. He told the group that if anyone is interested in writing a grant that he would find an opportunity.
DISCUSSION	A motion was made to adjourn the meeting by Chris Rishack, Paul King seconded the motion. All were in favor and meeting was adjourned at 8:02 pm.
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